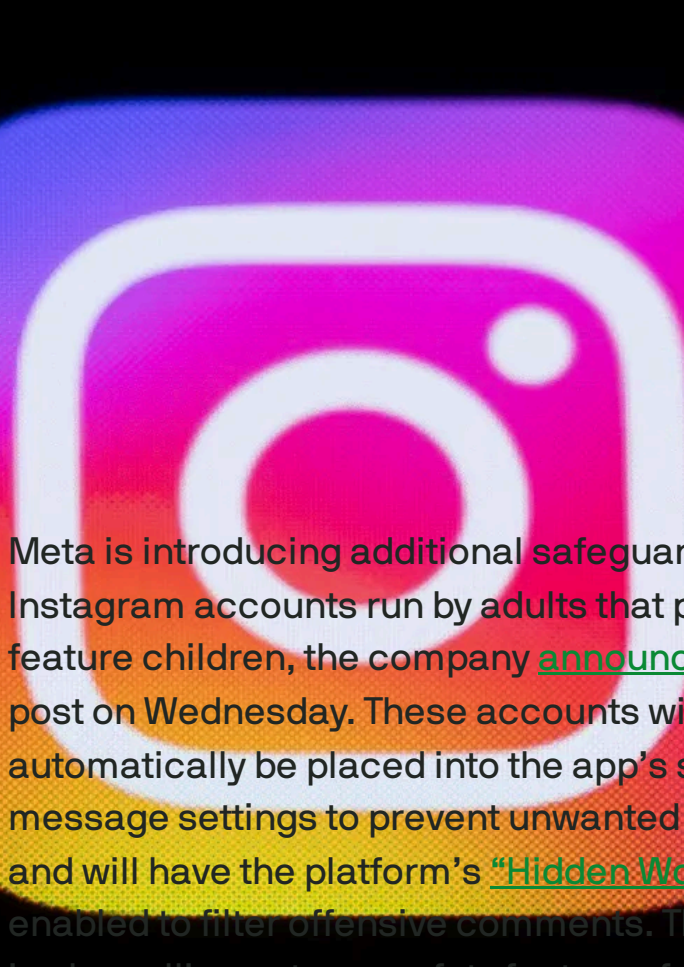


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Instagram adds new
protections for accounts
that primarily feature
children



Meta is introducing additional safeguards for Instagram accounts run by adults that primarily feature children, the company [announced](#) in a blog post on Wednesday. These accounts will automatically be placed into the app's strictest message settings to prevent unwanted messages and will have the platform's ["Hidden Words" feature](#) enabled to filter offensive comments. The company is also rolling out new safety features for teen accounts.

Accounts that will be placed into the new, stricter message settings include ones run by adults who regularly share photos and videos of their children, along with accounts run by parents or talent managers that represent children.

IMAGE CREDITS: [SILAS STEIN/PICTURE ALLIANCE](#)

"While these accounts are overwhelmingly used in benign ways, unfortunately, there are people who may try to abuse them, leaving sexualized comments under their posts or asking for sexual images in DMs, in clear violation of our rules," the company wrote in their blog post. "Today we're announcing steps to help prevent this abuse."

Meta says it will attempt to prevent potentially suspicious adults, such as people who have already been blocked by teens, from finding accounts that primarily feature children. Meta will avoid recommending suspicious adults to these accounts on Instagram, and vice versa, and make it

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harder for them to find each other in Instagram Search.

Today's announcement comes as Meta and Instagram have [taken steps](#) over the past year to address mental health concerns tied to social media. These concerns have been [raised by the U.S. Surgeon General](#) and various states, some of which have even [gone so far as to require](#) parental consent for access to social media.

The changes will significantly impact the accounts of family vloggers/creators and parents running accounts for “kidfluencers,” both of which have [faced criticism for the risks associated](#) with sharing children's lives on social media. A New York Times investigation published last year found that the [parents are often aware](#) of their child's exploitation or even participating in it, by selling photos or clothing their child wore. In The NYT's examination of 5,000 parent-run accounts, it found 32 million connections to male followers.

The company says the accounts that are placed into these stricter settings will see a notification at the top of their Instagram Feed notifying them that the social network has updated their safety settings. The notice will also prompt them to review their account privacy settings.

Meta notes it has removed almost 135,000 Instagram accounts that were sexualizing accounts that primarily feature children, as well as 500,000 Instagram and Facebook accounts that were associated with the original accounts it had removed.

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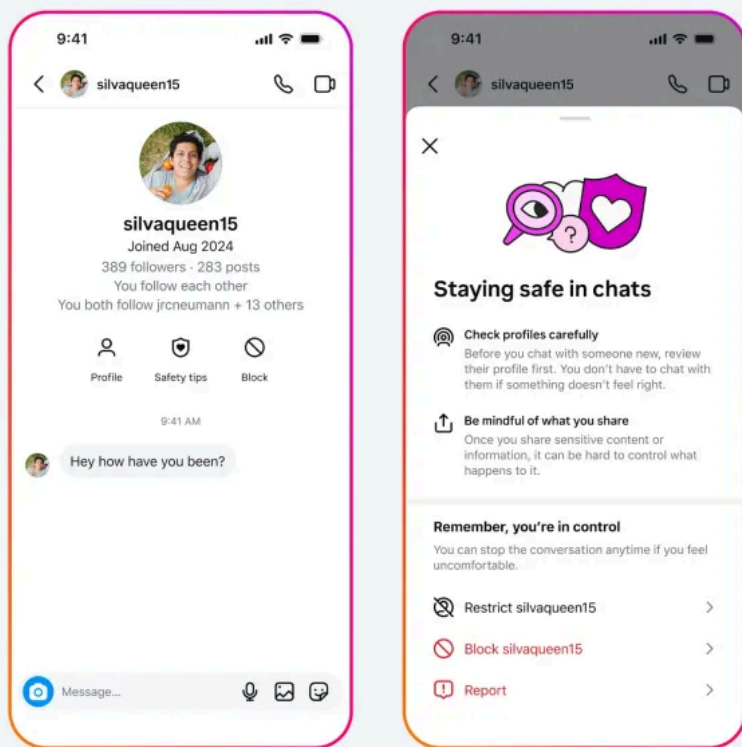


IMAGE CREDITS: META

Alongside today’s announcement, Meta is also bringing new safety features to DMs in [Teen Accounts](#), its app experience with built-in protections for teens that are automatically applied.

Teens will now see new options to view safety tips, reminding them to check profiles carefully and be mindful of what they share. Plus, the month and year that the account joined Instagram will be displayed at the top of new chats. In addition, Instagram has added a new block and report option that lets users do both things at the same time.

The new features are designed to give teens more context about the accounts they’re messaging and help them spot potential scammers, Meta says.

“These new features complement the safety notices we show to remind people to be cautious in private messages and to block and report anything that makes them uncomfortable — and we’re encouraged to see teens responding to them,” Meta wrote in the blog post. “In June alone, they

blocked accounts 1 million times and reported another 1 million after seeing a safety notice.”

Meta also provided an update on its [nudity protection filter](#), noting that 99% of people, including teens, have kept it turned on. Last month, over 40% of blurred images received in DMs stayed blurred, the company said.

Topics: [Apps](#) [children](#) [Instagram](#) [Meta](#) [Social](#)

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Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter | [X](#)

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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Meta is rolling out tighter teen messaging

limitations and parental controls

Ivan Mehta — 3:00 AM PST · January 25, 2024

Meta announced today that it is rolling out new DM restrictions on both Facebook and Instagram for teens that prevent anyone from messaging them unsolicitedly.

Until now, Instagram restricts adults over the age of 18 from messaging teens who don't follow them. The new limits will apply to all users under 16 — and in some geographies under 18 — by default. Meta said that it will notify existing users with a notification.

IMAGE CREDITS: [ALEXANDER SHATOV](#) / UNSPLASH

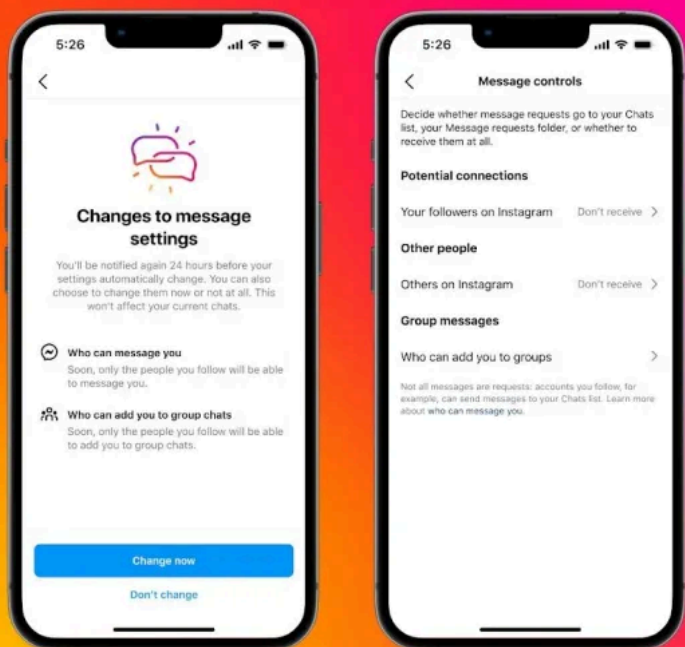


IMAGE CREDITS: META

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On Messenger, users will only get messages from Facebook friends, or people they have in their contacts.

What's more, Meta is also making its parental controls more robust by allowing guardians to allow or deny changes in default privacy settings made by teens. Previously, when teens changed these settings, [guardians got a notification](#), but they couldn't take any action on them.

The company gave an example that if a teen user tries to make their account public from private,

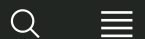
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IMAGE CREDITS: META

Meta first rolled out [parental supervision tools for Instagram in 2022](#), which gave guardians a sense of their teens' usage.

The social media giant said that it is also planning to launch a feature that will prevent teens from seeing unwanted and inappropriate images in their DMs sent by people connected to them. The company added that this feature will work in end-to-end encrypted chats as well and will "discourage" teens from sending these types of images.

TE

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Meta didn't specify what work it is doing to ensure the privacy of teens while executing these features. It also didn't provide details about what it considers to be "inappropriate."

Earlier this month, Meta rolled out new tools to [restrict teens from looking at self-harm or eating disorders on Facebook and Instagram](#).

Last month, Meta received [a formal request for information from the EU regulators](#), who asked the

company to provide more details about the company's efforts in preventing the sharing of self-generated child sexual abuse material (SG-CSAM).

At the same time, the company is facing [a civil lawsuit in the New Mexico state court](#), alleging that Meta's social network promotes sexual content to teen users and promotes underage accounts to predators. In October, [more than 40 U.S. states filed a lawsuit in a federal court in California](#) accusing the company of designing products in a way that harmed kids' mental health.

The company is set to testify before the Senate on issues around child safety on January 31 this year along with other social networks, including TikTok, Snap, Discord, and X (formerly Twitter).

Topics: [Apps](#) [Instagram](#) [Meta](#) [parental control](#)



Ivan Mehta

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Ivan covers global consumer tech developments at TechCrunch. He is based out of India and has previously...

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Instagram's new 'nighttime nudges' aim to reduce teens' time on the app

Aisha Malik — 7:25 AM PST · January 18, 2024

Instagram is introducing new nighttime nudges for teen accounts to limit their time on the app, the company **announced** on Thursday. The new nighttime nudges will appear when teens have spent more than 10 minutes on Instagram in places like Reels or DMs late at night. The notice will remind teens that it's late and encourage them to close the app and go to sleep.

Teens will start to see a notice that says "Time for a break?" followed by the message "It's getting late. Consider closing Instagram for the night." The social network told TechCrunch in an email that the nudges will appear after 10 p.m. The nighttime nudges will be shown automatically and can't be turned off, which means teens can't opt in or out of seeing them. Of course, teens have the option to simply dismiss the nudge and continue using the app.

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Ivan Mehta - 2 hours ago

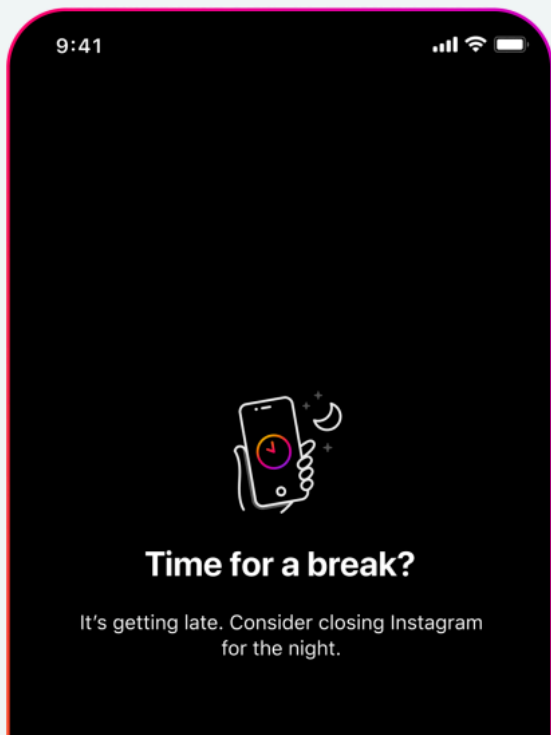


IMAGE CREDITS: INSTAGRAM

TikTok rolled out a [similar feature last March](#) that also reminds users to when it's time to put the app down and go to sleep.

The new nighttime nudges join Instagram's other features aimed at reducing teens' time on its app. The app already has a "Take a Break" feature that shows teens full-screen reminders to take regular breaks from Instagram, and a "Quiet Mode" feature that lets teens mute notifications and notify others that they are unavailable for a block of time.

Last week, [Meta announced](#) that it was going to automatically limit the type of content that teens can see on Instagram and Facebook. Teen accounts will automatically be restricted from seeing harmful content, such as posts about self-harm, graphic violence and eating disorders.

The new teen safety features come as Meta is facing regulatory pressure to do more to protect children. The company is scheduled to testify before the Senate on child safety on January 31. Executives from X (formerly Twitter), TikTok, Snap and Discord will also be testifying. Committee

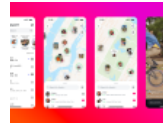
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Google takes on ChatGPT's Study Mode with new 'Guided Learning' tool in Gemini

Aisha Malik - 14 hours ago

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Instagram takes on Snapchat with new 'Instagram Map'

Aisha Malik - 19 hours ago

members are expected to press executives from the companies on their platforms' inability to protect children online.

In addition, [more than 40 states are suing Meta](#), alleging that the company's apps are contributing to young users' mental health problems. Meta has also received [another formal request for information \(RFI\)](#) from European Union regulators who are seeking more information about the company's response to child safety concerns on Instagram.

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Today's announcement comes a day after TechCrunch reported that internal Meta documents about child safety [revealed that Meta](#) not only intentionally marketed its apps to children, but was also aware of the significant amount of inappropriate and sexually explicit content being shared between adults and minors.

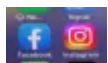
Unredacted Meta documents reveal 'historical reluctance' to protect children



Internal Meta documents about child safety have been unsealed as part of a lawsuit filed by the New Mexico Department of Justice against both Meta and its CEO, Mark Zuckerberg. The documents

reveal that Meta not only intentionally marketed its messaging platforms to children, but also knew about the massive volume of inappropriate and sexually explicit content being shared between adults and minors. [Continue reading](#)

Meta to restrict teen Instagram and Facebook accounts from seeing content about self-harm and eating disorders



Meta is going to automatically limit the type of content that teen Instagram and Facebook accounts can see on the platforms, the company announced on Tuesday. These accounts will automatically be restricted from seeing harmful content, such as posts about self-harm, graphic violence and eating disorders. The

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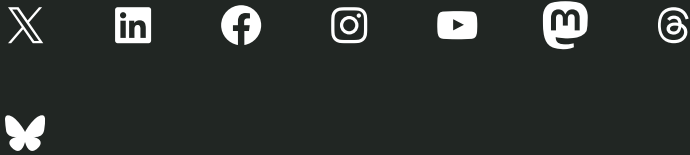
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